

## S02-02 - Eyes in the Brush

### Player read-aloud

A branch cracks somewhere beyond the road. For half a breath, the forest watches back.

### Scene summary

Hidden watchers prepare to spring the trap unless the PCs spot them first.

### Visible choices

- Instinct roll
- Draw weapons
- Call out
- Use carriage as cover

### Player questions

- What detail in Eyes in the Brush tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

### GM notes

- If Strixwolf Mercy applies, her distant warning cry can grant advantage here.
- Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it.
- Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.

### Checks and rolls

- Instinct Spot the scout net before it closes. Standard Avoid surprise or identify a negotiation angle. 15 Cleanly resolve: Spot the scout net before it closes. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Eyes in the Brush. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.

### Clues

- Signal knots An ambush is near. They planned for cargo, not slaughter. The watchers coordinate by tied bramble markers.

## Loot

- Signal knot
- Hidden boot track

## Mechanics

- Plot So Far: The party is in Act Two pressure: Hidden watchers prepare to spring the trap unless the PCs spot them first.
- Mechanics In Play: Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
- Roll Cards: s02-02-spot-watchers-before-the-ambush S02-02 Spot watchers before the ambush Spot watchers before the ambush Instinct Finesse Instinct Finesse 14 Instinct senses eyes; Finesse moves without giving away the scan. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Use a...
- Gm Fear Spends: Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclamer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Conditions Hazards: Hidden Restrained
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Escalation: Escalate by making cost visible: time, noise, trust, ward instability, or someone vulnerable in danger.
- Deescalation: De-escalate through respect, care, honest testimony, useful evidence, or a concrete concession.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Eyes in the Brush asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Finesse, Instinct, Knowledge. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Class Community Ancestry Reveals: Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

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